Why grow your own?

There is something rather satisfying about putting supper on the table and knowing that you grew part of it. You chose the crop, looked after it and picked it when it was ready. That small piece of independence is a good enough reason to begin. And here are a few others:

Grow the things you want to eat

A garden gives you choices that a shopping list does not. You can try a different variety, pick young leaves for lunch or grow something that rarely appears in the shops. If you like artichokes but seldom find them locally, they can be worth growing. Their value to you may be greater than their weight in a basket.

Save money from the start

You can begin growing with a very basic set of tools, and you can save money by making your own compost and reusing materials you already have. Grow the vegetables your household enjoys most. A small bed of salads, picked regularly, can provide plenty of fresh leaves and save you buying them each week.

Enjoy what the season gives you

Home growing brings abundance and gaps, sometimes in the same week. Eating with the seasons brings challenges but it also has its rewards. You will discover, for instance, why our ancestors feasted in the autumn and midwinter - because food is in surplus after the harvest. And why our bodies naturally become more active in the springtime. (Clue: Digging is physical work!)

Begin with one useful patch

You do not need to become self-sufficient, or grow everything in this book. One sunny bed, a few crops and a little attention will teach you more than a winter spent planning the perfect garden. Keep a note of what works, then build on it.

John: Hackriculture introduction; Food Independence; Money-Saving Tips.

Start with the right spot

Before you reach for the spade, spend a little time looking. Sunlight, water and access will shape this garden for years; moving a few pegs now is easier than moving the whole plot later.

Start with a patch you can look after. Leave room for the garden to grow later.

Sunlight comes first

Look for at least half a day of direct sun, preferably more. Check the shadows in spring as well as summer: a low wall may shade the soil just when you want it to warm up. Avoid planting beneath trees or beside a large hedge, where roots compete for water as well as light.

Look below the surface

Visit after rain and notice where water stands. On unfamiliar ground, dig a few small holes and inspect the soil for rubble and compacted soil before choosing dig or no-dig. In a new build home, for example, look first for buried building debris. A covering of compost would not make that debris disappear - it would have to be removed.

Put it within easy reach

Check that your hose reaches, or plan rainwater storage nearby. You need a convenient route for a loaded wheelbarrow and regular trips from the kitchen. A slightly imperfect patch that you visit every day may be more useful than a remote corner you keep forgetting.

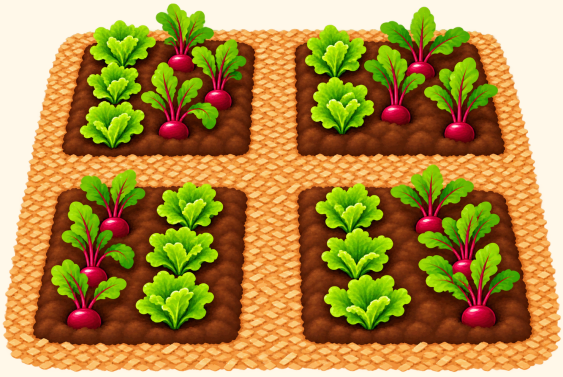
How much ground?

Begin with one bed and grow what you like eating. If you manage that comfortably, add another. Salads and regularly picked crops suit a small start; a winter's supply of potatoes needs more space. There is no single plot size that feeds every household, and taking on too much ground is a very quick way to lose the enjoyment.

John: Starting on New Ground; Sophia's Garden; Food Independence; Could I Feed Myself?

Beds and paths that work for you

Beds and paths can take several shapes. The useful question is whether you can reach the crops and move around comfortably. These three arrangements can work with digging or no-dig.



Straight paths connect across the plot.

Conventional paths

Straight paths divide the plot into rectangular beds. They make a straightforward route for carrying tools or pushing a barrow, and regular beds are convenient to cover with nets. Cross-paths save a long walk round, but use growing space. Keep them where they earn their keep, and make each bed narrow enough to tend from its edges.

A short path opens into a working space.

Keyhole beds

A short entrance opens into a standing space, with the bed wrapped around it. You can reach into the bed from this pocket as well as the outer edge, saving a path across the whole bed. It is useful where space is tight, but curved edges and the narrow entrance need careful setting out. Check your reach before planting.

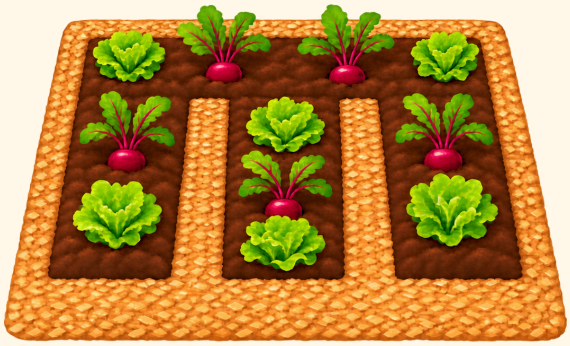
Keep the middle within reach

About 4 ft is a useful starting width for a bed reached from both sides, but your arms decide the final measurement. Make a bed against a wall narrower. You should be able to sow, weed and harvest every part without standing on the growing soil.

John: Raised Beds. RHS: raised beds. Garden Organic: Making Full Use of Space.

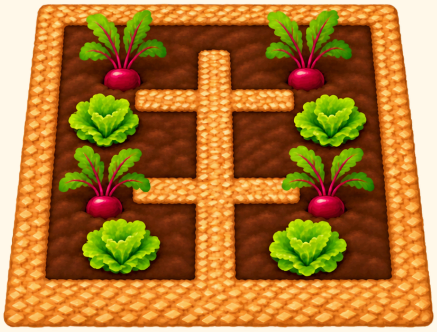
Beds and paths continued

Borrowing from nature



Finger paths enter from one side.

Finger paths are short paths that stop before the far edge, making a shape like the fingers in a hand. You gain extra growing space this way, but lose access from one edge.



A leaf pattern branches from a central path.

A plant leaf maximises photosynthesis area with veins spreading out from a central spine. You can mimic this pattern with your paths, to maximise your growing area.

Give the paths a shape that suits the ground, then try it out with pegs and string. A clever drawing is only useful if you can work from it.

Work with sun and slope

Where the site allows, run long beds north to south so tall crops share their shade across the day. Existing buildings and drainage may matter more than compass neatness. Watch where rain collects before settling the layout.

Try the paths for size

Peg out the edges, then walk the routes with a loaded barrow. Allow room to park, turn and work beside it. Check with everyone who will use the plot; a path that suits you may be awkward for somebody else.

Sides are optional

Mounded beds need no timber and leave fewer crevices for slugs in a wet garden. Framed beds hold a flatter surface and can raise the working height. Choose what makes the plot easier to use, then prepare the ground using the Cultivation pages.

John: Raised Beds; Sun, Drainage & Access, 00:03–05:37. Layout ideas, not scale plans.

Choose it, site it, set it up

A greenhouse buys you a longer growing season and a sheltered place for tender crops. Before choosing one, work out what will go inside it. Tomatoes have an unfortunate habit of being much larger in August than they were in April.

Choose useful growing room

Allow for mature plants, working space, an open door and roof vents. A small greenhouse can soon become crowded. A larger second-hand frame may cost surprisingly little, but check that it is sound and complete, and allow for dismantling, transport and replacement glass. Photograph joints before taking it apart.

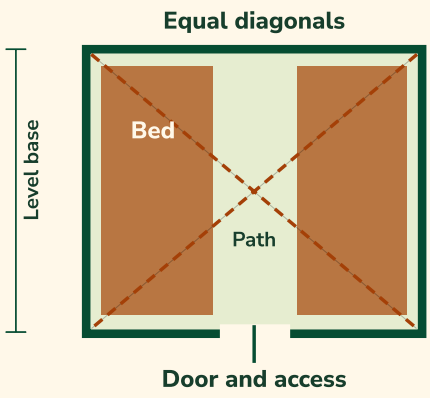
Find the sunny position

Choose a bright, reasonably sheltered place, clear of overhanging branches, with water and a convenient path nearby. Leave space outside to clean and repair the glazing. Mark the footprint with string, then mark the beds or staging inside it; a building that fits the garden may still be awkward to work in.

Look at glazing and ventilation

Ordinary horticultural glass breaks into sharp shards. Toughened glass breaks into smaller pieces; polycarbonate is another glazing option and diffuses the light. Check how panels are retained and what replacements cost. Opening roof vents and a usable door matter far more than decorative extras.

Check the footprint before you build



Install in this order

1 Prepare the base

Use the exact base dimensions and foundation arrangement for the model. Check levels in both directions and measure the diagonals to make the rectangle square.

2 Anchor and assemble

Secure the base and frame with the specified fixings. Follow the assembly sequence and fit the bracing before glazing; do not rely on the weight of the glass to hold it down.

3 Glaze and check

Work with a helper, gloves and eye protection. Fit panes and clips as directed, then check the door, vents, gutter and drainage. Recheck fixings before the first storm.

John: greenhouse chapters; Money-Saving Tips, 12:00–18:20. Halls: glazing and assembly.

Give the roots some room

Soil beds in a greenhouse give roots room to grow and hold a reserve of moisture. They also save a considerable procession of pots and bags of potting compost.

One possible arrangement: raised soil beds, a clear path and a frame lifted to preserve headroom.

Plan the beds before the base

On soil, leave the growing areas open to the ground below. Loosen construction-compacted soil before filling with topsoil and mature compost, or build a no-dig surface over suitable ground. Brick-edged beds can sit above the outside soil level for drainage; a raised greenhouse frame preserves height for tall plants. Plan a clear doorway at the same time.

Keep the simpler option

You do not have to build internal brick walls. A smaller greenhouse can have mounded growing areas with a woodchip path between them. On a paved site, use suitable containers instead. Whatever the arrangement, check root moisture regularly; a soil bed gives you a buffer, not permission to forget the watering.

Use it through the seasons

Early salads can occupy space before the summer crops need it. Remove spinach as it begins to crowd the tomatoes; after summer, suitable autumn salads can follow. Use the crop guides for timing. Open doors and vents in warm weather, shade when needed, and clean the glass and service moving parts before the new season.

If root disease develops, identify it before reusing the ground. Rotate where practical, or use containers with fresh compost; do not carry affected soil into clean beds.

John: greenhouse chapter; January repairs; May abundance; Winter Composting. Tomato JSON; RHS ventilation.

Simple crop rotation

Rotation means moving a crop to different ground instead of planting it in the same place year after year. Its most useful job in a small garden is to reduce the build-up of problems shared by related plants.

One bed, three different families

An example of changing families, not a compulsory three-year prescription.

Keep a simple record

Sketch your beds and write down what grew where, including a second crop in the same year. Next season, move the main crop to ground that held an unrelated family. Changing cabbage for broccoli does not count: they share too many problems.

Fit the plan to your appetite

A flexible core rotation need not use four equal blocks. Small beds let you grow more of what your household eats. Keep permanent crops, such as asparagus, outside the annual shuffle. Move kitchen onions each year, as their crop guide advises.

These crops travel together

Brassicas	Cabbage, kale, broccoli, radish and turnip
Alliums	Onion, shallot, leek and garlic
Legumes	Peas and beans
Potato family	Potatoes and tomatoes
Carrot family	Carrot, parsnip, coriander and dill

A rotation is not a disease cure

Clubroot and onion white rot can remain in soil for many years. A short circuit round the beds does not make infected ground clean. Use the Troubles guides for the diagnosed problem, keep contaminated soil off clean beds, and do not put infected allium debris into good compost.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes. Crop and Troubles JSON; Garden Organic family table.

A good bin makes the job easier

Composting keeps useful material in the garden. Last year's plant waste becomes part of next year's growing medium. The important bit is giving it somewhere convenient to break down.

Filling

Add new material here as it arrives.

Rotting

Leave the full bin to break down.

Ready

Keep finished compost until needed.

Why three bins help

With two bins, you may need to bag up finished compost to make room. Three bins let each job have its own space. You do not have to shovel the contents along a row: the bins change jobs as they become empty. With only two, finish using one before you need to start filling it again.

Buy one or make one

For a bought bin, look for a sound lid, sturdy sides, a secure rodent-resistant base and an opening you can actually empty through. Check the capacity against your busiest season. A second matching bin is often more useful than a clever gadget attached to the first.

A straightforward timber version

1

Set out the bays

Choose a level, accessible spot near both kitchen and garden. Leave working room in front. Fix sound posts securely and use stout boards for the backs, sides and divisions.

2

Make it accessible

Use removable front boards so a fork or shovel can reach the bottom. Fit rainproof lids that you can lift safely. Keep some ventilation without leaving the contents exposed on every side.

3

Close the gaps

Secure a suitable metal rodent barrier across the base and its edges, while allowing drainage and soil life access. Check joints, lids and damaged boards regularly. Brick walls are an option for a permanent version.

John: Compost Bins chapter; My Compost Method, 00:01–04:50; Why We Make Compost.

Feed it, leave it, use it

You can make good compost by adding material as the household produces it. There is no need to save everything for one grand filling day, or weigh every cabbage leaf against a piece of cardboard.

A mixture going in; dark, crumbly compost coming out. Return coarse pieces to the active bin.

Mix what goes in

Combine soft green material, such as vegetable peelings and fresh leaves, with browns such as torn plain cardboard and chopped stalks. Remove tape and staples. Mix grass clippings through other material rather than adding a thick wet lump. Keep a big autumn fall of leaves in a separate pile to rot slowly.

Keep the moisture even

Dampen dry cardboard and other dry additions as they go in. Close the lid to keep heavy rain out and moisture in, then check below the fresh top layer during dry weather. In these enclosed bins, there is no need for routine turning. If yours stalls, check for dry corners or wet clumps; break these up, adding water to dry material or dry browns to a soggy mix.

Judge the compost, not the calendar

Finished compost is dark, crumbly and earthy, with little recognisable soft plant material. Pick out remaining coarse stalks and return them to the filling bin. Give slow material more time. A resting bin may spend many months getting ready; the plants will not thank you for impatience.

Put it back to work

Spread mature compost on no-dig beds, or incorporate it when preparing a dug bed. Keep it clear of established soft stems. For potting on, sieve equal volumes of good mature compost and garden topsoil and mix them thoroughly. Try a small batch first: the ingredients vary from garden to garden.

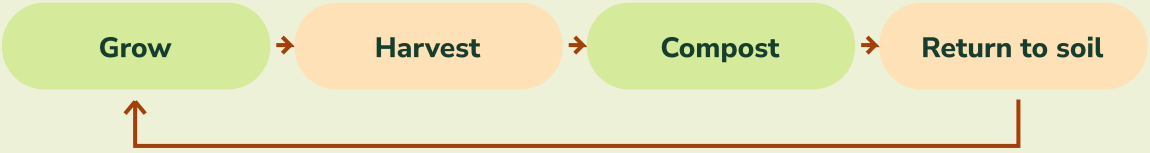
Keep plastic-coated card and doubtful “compostable” packaging out. Unless you have a suitable system that excludes rodents, send cooked food, meat, fish and dairy to your council’s food-waste collection where available.

John: Compost and Potting Mixtures; Compost Method; Five Things; Winter Composting; Why We Make Compost.

Organic growing: the core ideas

Organic growing begins with a useful bit of housekeeping: keep as much plant material as possible in the garden, turn it into compost and return it to the soil. Then pay attention to what grows well there.

Keep useful material in the garden



Return suitable scraps and plant waste. Add outside compost when the garden cannot make enough.

Look after the ground

Use mature compost to improve the soil and replenish what crops take from it. Keep feet and barrow wheels on the paths. Dig or no-dig can both be part of this approach; choose a method that suits the soil and the work you can comfortably do.

Work with the place you have

A plant in the right conditions usually needs less rescuing. Grow the crops and varieties that suit your ground, give them room, and avoid pushing seedlings out into cold, wet soil. Keep a record of successes as well as failures. It is remarkably easy to forget the name of a good variety.

Deal with the cause

Look closely before reaching for a remedy. Check moisture, roots and recent weather, then use the appropriate Troubles guide. Hand-pick damaging pests where practical and fit suitable crop protection. Keep bird netting taut and check it regularly; loose loops can trap the birds you wanted to exclude.

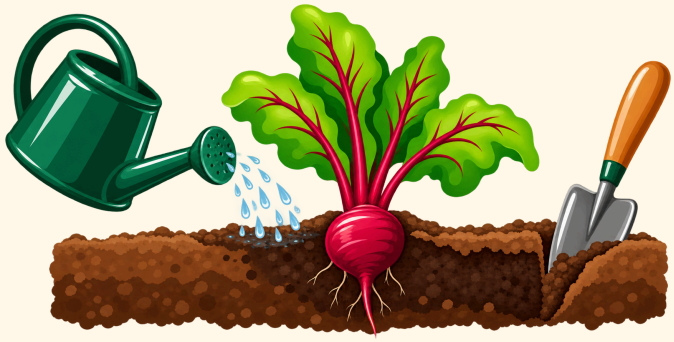
Experiment on a small patch

A thick hay-and-straw mulch that works well in a drier climate can shelter slugs on cold, wet ground. Try new ideas on a manageable area before changing the whole garden. Keep what works, understand why it works, and feel free to adapt it.

John: Into the Zone; both 35 Years videos; Why We Make Compost. Canonical organic controls.

Water the roots, read the soil

A drooping plant is asking you to investigate. It may be dry, too wet or simply struggling with heat. Adding another can of water without checking can make the wrong problem worse.



Aim at the soil. Check moisture beneath the surface rather than judging by the leaves alone.

Check before you pour

Feel below the surface with a finger or trowel, taking care around roots. Dry, loose material needs water; wet, sticky soil needs a chance to drain. With pots, check the compost and learn the difference in weight between a watered pot and a dry one. A dry crust can hide damp ground underneath.

Water thoroughly when needed

Apply water slowly around the rooting area so it soaks in rather than running away. Established beds generally benefit more from a proper watering than a daily sprinkle on top. Newly sown seed, small seedlings and recent transplants are exceptions: their shallow roots need steady moisture, checked frequently.

Give surplus water an exit

Keep container drainage holes clear and avoid leaving vegetable pots standing in water. Where rain collects in a bed, check for blocked surface outlets. Loosen compacted ground using the Cultivation method, or raise the growing surface as described in Planning a New Plot. Roots need air; wilting in sodden soil is a reason to investigate, not add water.

Make the job manageable

Collect rainwater from suitable roofs into covered butts on firm, stable stands. Keep the supply close enough to use easily. Soil beds hold more reserve than small pots, but check both in hot weather. Newly planted brassicas can struggle in a heatwave despite daily watering; delaying planting and providing temporary shade may help more than another soaking.

John: Raised Beds, Water Collection and UK Heatwave. Crop JSON; RHS watering guidance.

Sowing and planting: a sound start

The crop guide gives you the season and method. Your weather and soil decide whether today is a sensible day to begin. A head start only helps if the plants keep growing.

Sow directly, or raise plants separately. Harden indoor-raised plants before planting out.

Direct into the bed

Prepare a fine, firm surface and remove competing weeds. Make a drill at the depth given for the crop; water it first if dry. Sow, cover and firm gently, then keep the seed zone moist. On coarse no-dig compost, use a little sieved compost in the drill and over the seed.

Start under cover

Modules give early crops a start while outside soil is still cold. Sow at the crop's depth, label with variety and date, and give the seedlings light and steady moisture. Use modules early in the year; later, a small outdoor nursery bed is often easier than nursing young outdoor crops through a hot greenhouse.

Plant them out

Harden indoor-raised plants gradually: put them outside in a sheltered spot by day and return them under cover at night, increasing exposure over two to three weeks. Keep tender crops from frost. Water before lifting, preserve the roots, and plant at the crop's stated depth and spacing. Firm gently and water in.

A small experiment: mixed salad leaves

For an odd corner, try broadcasting mixed salad seed. Choose crops with compatible sowing times, covering depths and picking sizes. Scatter evenly, cover as required and water gently. Thin before the strongest swamp the rest, and keep a separate main sowing of any crop you are relying on.

Sow little and often where the crop allows it. Check the individual guide before treating all seeds, plugs or planting depths alike; carrots, lettuces and peas do not start in the same way.

John: No-dig sowing, module notes and Chuck It Around. Crop JSON; RHS hardening off.